Reading Public Bail Records

What a small test of Allegheny County dockets found — and what it can’t tell us

Volunteer briefing · Prepared October 5, 2026 · Interim results (44 of 200 dockets)

THE PREMISE

Why we did this

- Finding bail information in court records by hand is slow, and it’s easy to mix up a bail amount with a fee or fine.
- We tested whether a simple, careful process could read **public** docket sheets and pull out just the bail entry: the type and the amount the court set.
- The goal is to help volunteers **understand the picture** — not to pick, rank, or decide on anyone’s case.
- Every result has to be checked by a person against the original court record before anyone relies on it.

HOW IT WAS DONE

Ground rules we followed

- **Public source only:** the Pennsylvania courts' free UJS Portal (ujsportal.pacourts.us). No logins, no workarounds.
- **Minimal personal data:** we kept docket numbers, bail type, amount, and whether bail was shown as posted. No names, birth dates, addresses, or charges.
- **Fair selection:** cases were taken in the order the court website lists them, by filing date — never by anything about the person.
- **No documents kept:** each docket PDF was deleted right after the bail section was read.
- **Stop when told to:** when the court site signaled too many requests, we stopped.

ROUND ONE

First test: 10 dockets

- 10 criminal cases filed **October 1, 2026**, at local magisterial district courts.
- We looked for monetary bail of **$100 or less**. **None found.**
- What we saw: 3 cases with monetary bail ($1,000, $1,000, $2,000), 2 with nonmonetary release ($0), and 5 with no bail section at all.

Limits of that first search

- Tiny sample — one day, a handful of court offices.
- Very recent cases only. Bail often changes after the first hearing, and people held a long time have **older** cases.
- Higher-level Common Pleas court cases were not included.
- Our first tool needed a manual tweak to read the real court layout — since fixed and retested.

ROUND TWO

Second test: what changed

- Planned **200 dockets**, filed Sept 27–30, 2026, searched one day at a time.
- Raised the look-for line to monetary bail **under $500**, to see more of the spread.
- Excluded any case where the docket shows bail was **already posted**.
- Built-in checks: the reader was tested on 17 sample cases (all passed) before touching real records.
- **The court site stopped us at 44 dockets** (a “too many requests” signal). We did not try to get around it.

WHAT WE FOUND

Results: 44 dockets read

33

had **no bail section** on the docket sheet yet

3

nonmonetary release ($0)

7

monetary bail, **$1,000 to $20,000**

1

monetary bail under $500 — **$1.00**, unconfirmed

Monetary amounts seen: $1 (once), $1,000 (once), $5,000 (four times), $10,000 (once), $20,000 (once). None of the 44 showed bail as posted — but that does **not** mean anyone is in jail.

READ WITH CARE

The one entry under $500

Docket	MJ-05003-CR-0006860-2026
Court	Magisterial District Court, Allegheny County
Bail entry as shown	Set · Monetary · $1.00
Bail posted?	No posted record on the docket sheet
Checked against the source?	Not yet — the court site blocked further requests
Possible explanation	Pennsylvania has a “nominal bail” option that uses a token amount like $1. This may be that, not ordinary cash bail.

This is a discovery result, not a recommendation. A stated bail amount does not tell us what is needed for release, whether the person is in custody, whether there are other holds, or eligibility for help.

LIMITATIONS

What these results can’t tell us

- **Who is in jail.** Court dockets don’t show custody, and we found no official online jail roster.
- **Long-term detention.** These were brand-new cases. People held for weeks or months would appear in older filings and in Common Pleas court.
- **Why 3 in 4 had no bail section.** Could be a summons instead of arrest, or bail not yet entered — we didn’t investigate.
- **The whole county.** 44 cases from four days is a snapshot, not a census.
- **Spot checks.** The 44 rows were read by the tool; each still needs a person to compare it with the court record.

BACKGROUND

Context: who is in the jail

- Pretrial detainees — people **not yet convicted** — were “nearly half of the jail’s population” in October 2025 (Pittsburgh Post-Gazette).
- Pretrial detention plus probation detainers together account for about **80%** of the jail population (New Pittsburgh Courier, Aug. 2025). Probation detainers usually can’t be resolved by paying bail.
- Average length of stay fell from 74 days (2024) to 42 days (2025), but some people stay far longer (Post-Gazette).

Sources: post-gazette.com/news/social-services/2025/10/13/allegheny-county-jail-population-budget/stories/202510130015 · newpittsburghcourier.com/2025/08/16/why-is-allegheny-county-jail-getting-more-crowded/

OPTIONS FOR THE GROUP

Where this could go next

- **Finish the 200** at a slower pace the court site tolerates (about one request every 30 seconds).
- **Look at older cases**, including Common Pleas court, to see bail for people held longer.
- **Confirm by hand** any low-amount entry against the original docket before discussing it.
- **Find better custody data** — such as the county’s jail reports — instead of guessing from dockets.

FULL RESULTS

Appendix: all 44 dockets (1 of 2)

#	Docket	Filed	Bail type	Amount	Posted?
1	MJ-05306-CR-0000637-2026	09/30/2026	Nonmonetary	$0.00	No record
2	MJ-05304-CR-0000256-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
3	MJ-05304-CR-0000255-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
4	MJ-05304-CR-0000254-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
5	MJ-05304-CR-0000253-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
6	MJ-05304-CR-0000252-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
7	MJ-05304-CR-0000251-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
8	MJ-05304-CR-0000250-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
9	MJ-05304-CR-0000249-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
10	MJ-05304-CR-0000248-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
11	MJ-05304-CR-0000247-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
12	MJ-05304-CR-0000246-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
13	MJ-05304-CR-0000245-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
14	MJ-05304-CR-0000244-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
15	MJ-05303-CR-0000215-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
16	MJ-05232-CR-0000144-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
17	MJ-05225-CR-0000395-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
18	MJ-05222-CR-0000152-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$5,000.00	No record
19	MJ-05221-CR-0000179-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
20	MJ-05221-CR-0000178-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
21	MJ-05220-CR-0000353-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
22	MJ-05217-CR-0000193-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record

FULL RESULTS

Appendix: all 44 dockets (2 of 2)

#	Docket	Filed	Bail type	Amount	Posted?
23	MJ-05217-CR-0000192-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
24	MJ-05216-CR-0000364-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
25	MJ-05214-CR-0000629-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$5,000.00	No record
26	MJ-05213-CR-0000739-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
27	MJ-05212-CR-0000229-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$20,000.00	No record
28	MJ-05212-CR-0000228-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
29	MJ-05212-CR-0000227-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
30	MJ-05207-CR-0000714-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
31	MJ-05207-CR-0000713-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$10,000.00	No record
32	MJ-05206-CR-0000585-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
33	MJ-05204-CR-0000238-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
34	MJ-05204-CR-0000237-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
35	MJ-05203-CR-0000348-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$1,000.00	No record
36	MJ-05203-CR-0000347-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
37	MJ-05202-CR-0000710-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$5,000.00	No record
38	MJ-05202-CR-0000709-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
39	MJ-05003-CR-0006863-2026	09/30/2026	Nonmonetary	$0.00	No record
40	MJ-05003-CR-0006862-2026	09/30/2026	Nonmonetary	$0.00	No record
41	MJ-05003-CR-0006861-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record
42	MJ-05003-CR-0006860-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$1.00	No record
43	MJ-05003-CR-0006859-2026	09/30/2026	Monetary	$5,000.00	No record
44	MJ-05003-CR-0006858-2026	09/30/2026	—	—	No record